Alefiya J Malubhoy
Professor Tania Roy
EN3241
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**Coagulating Abjection in the Turn of the Screw**

godhood is just
like girlhood:
a begging to be believed
— Kirstin Chang, *Churching*

## Introduction

Implicated in the psychoanalytic interpretation of the Turn of the Screw is the responsibility of the manuscript passed from hand to hand on the brink of death: creating a narrative chain, which only reveals itself as a chain at all because the person to whom it was bequeathed had been loved (Felman 128). The original author of the manuscript, the unnamed Governess, entrusts her story to Douglas, the brother of one of her charges who was deeply in love with her, before she dies; Douglas in turn entrusts it to the narrator. This love is unspoken, understood in the action (as Douglas says, "If she hadn't [liked me] she wouldn't have told me"; 5) which is posthumous: so love-death propels us over and over again in a circle of opacity.

Felman's interpretation in the Lacanian mode moves us centripetally to where the threatening Real pushes one to the Imaginary and the Other, the centre which is the hyphen that yokes 'love' and 'death.' It is in Kristeva that we identify it, recognised by Freud as an "unplumable navel" (Gay 134), to be the chora, our point of origin. The chora is enveloped and envelopes, just as the love-death chain is simultaneously the centre and the frame of the Turn of

the Screw. The Other, then, is what lies in-between: the story itself unfolding in Bly, bordered by the Real, between birth and death – and this boundary, where the Real infringes on the Other, is what Kristeva calls abjection.

**Interpreting the Other**

The Real is characterised by an overwhelming animality, lost in base sensation, where language has no function, thus constantly threatens the fragility of the Other that we give ourselves meaning in. The eminent arrival of the ghosts of Miss Jessel and Peter Quint is narratively foreshadowed by the governess as "the spring of a beast" (25), but what really betrays them as harbingers of the Real are the reactions of the governess herself. Her confrontations with the ghosts result in "wildness of grief" and "outbreaks of sharper passion" which ultimately "overflow in a deluge" (65, 118, 147). She succumbs to the excess of the Real, unable to put her emotions into words.

The ghosts are characterised by their presence at the very boundaries, obscured and kept away by windows (Quint) and pools (Jessel). Both these spaces grant two things: distance from the viewer who must look through glass and across water, and a reflection a mirage of themselves or their surroundings in the course of looking at the ghost. It seems an almost imitation of the Lacanian mirror stage, where we must misrecognise ourselves, and see as Miles does, "the frames and squares of the great window [as] a kind of image, for him, of a kind of failure" (139). The foundation of the Other is threatened by a shift in perception that once again dispels our tenuous specular image to reveal the ghost of the Real behind it.

It is the Real, the ghosts, which she believes she must protect the children from – "I was a screen—I was to stand before them," she declares (47). The screen is a symptom of motherhood,

to Kristeva, that which stands between the child and abyss of the Real. She consciously eschews her role as the governess to assume that of the mother, refusing to simply quit her employ and "put an end to [her] predicament by leaving altogether" (97). She repeatedly and inscrutably *chooses* to take on this burden, and this is what separates her from Mrs. Grose, despite how she sometimes "envies the simplicity of [Mrs Grose's] relation [with Flora]" (117).

It is this assumption of motherhood that produces her delusion: she slips—as Freud tells us—along the symbolic line, where the children fulfil her desire for the penis of the Master, their uncle's, and thus she loves them to the point where they are her only reprieve from the evil she believes is haunting her. But simultaneously, she hates them because they do not belong to her—as Kristeva says—and hence cannot fulfil her desire for ownership since they are autonomous and belong to the Other, outside of her. The two contradictory attitudes the governess displays in her madness are displays of the split motherhood, "the abyss between what was mine and is now irreparably alien" (Kristeva, *Tales of Love* 325).

This pseudo-motherhood, however, denies her more on the second count – the children never belonged to her because they are not hers, she has not birthed them. She must, then, compensate by slipping further on the first count – she recreates herself as a symbolic mother to the children and symbolic wife to the master and thus becomes symbolic mistress in Bly manor. The letter she at first refused to write becomes not only an admittance of her failure in her duty but also the failure of her carefully crafted delusion. The letters in the story are hidden from us, but gradually the realization enters the mind of the reader that the manuscript is a letter itself. The letter meant for the master was burnt; the manuscript, then, is more than an unreliable narrator – it is a desperation and determined rewriting. It is the manuscript, the product of the

Other, that she turns to in order to transform her delusion to reality, perhaps even allow her to sublimate her desire for what she did not have.

**Edging Abjection**

What we must see in the text, therefore, is precisely what is not said, and what seems conspicuously missing. Where the Real and the Other collide, there lies abjection. However, the story, for all its horror, is a clean text: the word 'blood' appears only once (25) as she describes the beauty of her children. Her encounters with the ghosts, rather than cause an open wound which spurts blood, drain her of blood and leave her "white as a sheet" (37) in a description that evokes blankness, not violence.

The manuscript seems almost scraped clean, eroded: even the descriptions of the house and its empty rooms are never accompanied by dust or dirt, maintained as they apparently are by Mrs Grose (74). Though death permeates the narration in its entirety, it does not sully it or make itself known through the abject – we ourselves have *condensed* the concepts into love-death. However, the question of *why* the governess chose to not only silence but make a void of the abject is not as easily answered: would it not make her more of a heroine, to protect the children from gore and violence?

I fall back to Kristeva: I posit that the reason for silencing the abject, for maintaining a purity, is an attempt to inherit the Master-Mother who has never been penetrated – this is, of course, the figure of the Virgin Mary to the governess, daughter of a parson. And it is that very unique limit of social class—beyond illiteracy but before wealth—which grants the governess, like the feudal Lady, that what "excluded all other women […] embodied an absolute authority the more attractive" (Kristeva, *Tales of Love* 319). However, unlike the Lady, she is excluded

from all social convention that can allow her to wield it: marriage and pregnancy. But, like the Virgin, she is deprived of sex, the act of copulation. *This* is the reason she chooses to take on the burden of the screen: she reimagines herself as the Virgin who saved humanity.

It seems no surprise, then, her disgust for Miss Jessel who wished to be intimate with Quint (55): she revulsed sex because she was now the Virgin; Miss Jessel became Eve, who doomed humanity and corrupted her children. If one presses the Christian reading, we can even say that the master is much the Holy Spirit, who granted children without penetrating her, and left her to her own devices to raise the child. The delusion she harbours that Miles will be saved if he confesses to his crime of stealing the letter seems only an extension of the Christian confessional box – much like a window, a boundary between what can be said and what cannot.

She denies the abject in the manuscript because the Virgin is pure and free from it, to become the Virgin she too must free herself of the unclean. Since we would not be able to read her manuscript if her delusion was complete, we must read the silences to imagine what is not there, and so what could it have been that interrupted this delusion, what indeed "disturbs [her] identity, system, order" (Kristeva, "Approaching Abjection" 3) in a way she has no control over? I say it is that abject which constantly and unfailingly dismantles her – menstruation, menstrual blood, which simultaneously pushes her away from the Virgin[1] and from real motherhood.

Her menstrual cycle, which she undoubtedly experienced during her time at Bly, would have been a painful reminder, almost a punishment for not being either a real mother or the Virgin. Worse, it would seem to her that she expels the corpse of an unborn, undead child. The source of it is something that she cannot prevent – unlike wounds or dirt, which she can take

[1] It is a matter of contention whether the Virgin menstruated or not; however, the dominant view that Christianity perpetuates seems to give her divinity by depriving her of menstruation too (University of Dayton).

caution to ensure they never occur – her own biology betrays her, rejects the madness she can sublimate into the Other. The blood and its abjection become a risk, something that shocks the reader into drawing away from the dialectic of the Other to acknowledge the Real.

**Conclusion**

The abjection, thus necessarily denied, becomes a void between the Real and the Other, the hyphen between ‘love’ and ‘death’ which does not bridge but separates. The love-death narrative chain that stoppers the story—the chora that is the centre and the frame—is bound by the lack of abjection: it floats around the Other, damming the blood of abjection, which coagulates around the edges.

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